T.A. Boase, chief engineer—officers whose salaries would have been quite high.[148]

What indeed was the problem with the *Gallia*? The *Gallia*, though ‘a new and excellent steamer’, the directors claimed, was giving ‘very great trouble’ with the boilers—the heart of any steamer. ‘(B)esides causing a heavy consumption of coal’, it was ‘somewhat unsuitable for our service’. More damningly, the directors confessed that, ‘[e]xcept for a few trips off and on, the steamer has been laid up in the Colombo harbour from September last’. To allow it to run would have been ‘ruinous’ to the company.[149] More than a decade later, a British port officer criticized SSNCo for their choice of steamer: ‘They bought a 24-knot old ship, the very last sort of thing which you can possibly make pay. The boilers were out and this new company bought such a ship to start with.’[150] The comment is cryptic, and a non-expert is unable to make out what was really wrong. Perhaps the ship was unsuitable, and the boilers were not as efficient as they should have been. We really do not know at this distance in time.

There was, however, a small consolation. SSNCo succeeded in claiming a refund of premium from the underwriters for the *Gallia* for the non-performance of boilers.[151] A substantial Rs 22,690-6-0 of the insurance of Rs 33,203-9-0 had been refunded. No doubt a welcome saving, but it counted for little as a stationary ship served no purpose.

What was the solution? Experts whom the company consulted recommended fitting the *Gallia* with new (‘proper’) boilers. Quotations were called for, and it was estimated that it would cost anywhere up to Rs 60,000—more than a good quarter of the purchase price. Considering that it was the newer, if smaller, of the two steamers—it had been built only in 1904—it is inexplicable why the boilers should break down.[152] The district superintendent of police claimed that it had been ‘sold cheap on account of defective construction’.[153] This needs to be taken with caution as the *Gallia* had been classed by both the Lloyd’s Register and Bureau Veritas. Further, while we cannot say anything about its construction, the *Gallia* was far from cheap.